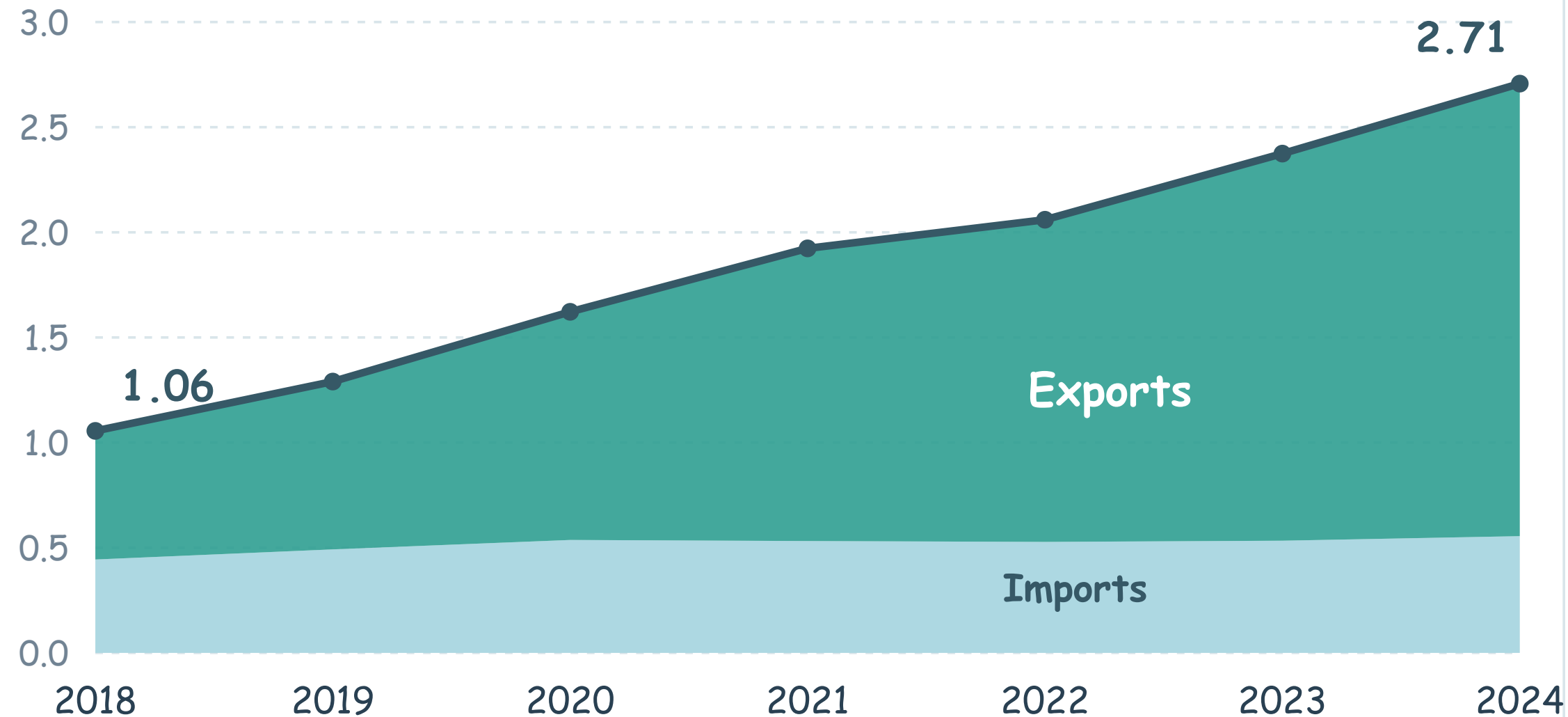


01 TRADE GROWTH IS LED BY EXPORTS

Cross-border e-commerce trade

China · 2018-2024 · RMB trillion



A slower growth rate still means expansion

Annual growth was uneven: 25.7% in 2020, 7.1% in 2022, 15.3% in 2023 and 14.0% in 2024. The total kept rising across these years, even when the growth rate slowed. For firms, this distinction matters: slower growth is still expansion, but stock and delivery plans may need to allow for different rates of change. [1]

Exports account for most of the expansion

China's cross-border e-commerce trade rose from RMB 1.06 trillion in 2018 to RMB 2.71 trillion in 2024, up 156.4%. Exports increased by 251.9%, against 25.0% for imports. The gap means that the expansion was concentrated in selling abroad. Imports also grew, so their falling share should not be confused with an absolute fall in purchases from overseas.

What this means for firms

The trade mix links China's growth to overseas customers and the services needed to fulfil their orders. Our interpretation is that firms should consider customer acquisition, payments and delivery together when planning export activity. A growing national total can provide context for that planning, but it does not show demand for an individual product. The figures establish which trade component expanded; they do not isolate the causes.